should trust China. During his January 2016 visit to Tehran, Xi Jinping cited China's support for "Iran's nuclear case" as an example of the mutual trust and independent policies existing between China and Iran.[7]

Formation of the Sino–Iranian "comprehensive strategic partnership"

A key objective behind Beijing's proposal of expanded post-JCPOA Sino–Iranian cooperation was to secure Iran's buy-in on Xi Jinping's BRI project. Iran was initially hesitant to embrace the BRI programme announced by Xi Jinping in October 2013 (then called "One Belt, One Road" – OBOR). A report by a researcher, Liu Jin, from Beijing's Academy of Social Sciences drafted after several months of investigation in Tehran identified several reasons for Iran's hesitation regarding BRI.[8] One reason was that President Hasan Rouhani had prioritised lifting international economic sanctions via a deal with the Western powers over Iran's nuclear programmes. Rouhani feared that embrace of BRI would be seen by the United States and Europe as a challenge to them, thus causing problems for the push to secure lifting of economic sanctions. Iranian leaders' understanding of BRI was not deep, Lu Jin found, and China needed to explain BRI to assuage Iranian apprehensions. The lifting of sanctions on Iran would greatly increase the competitive challenge by European and American firms to Chinese firms seeking opportunities in Iran. Thus, Lu Jin explained, China needed to bolster the competitive position of Chinese firms. Lu Jin clearly envisioned China engaged in an intense competitive game in Iran but saw Europe and the United States, not India, as China's rival.